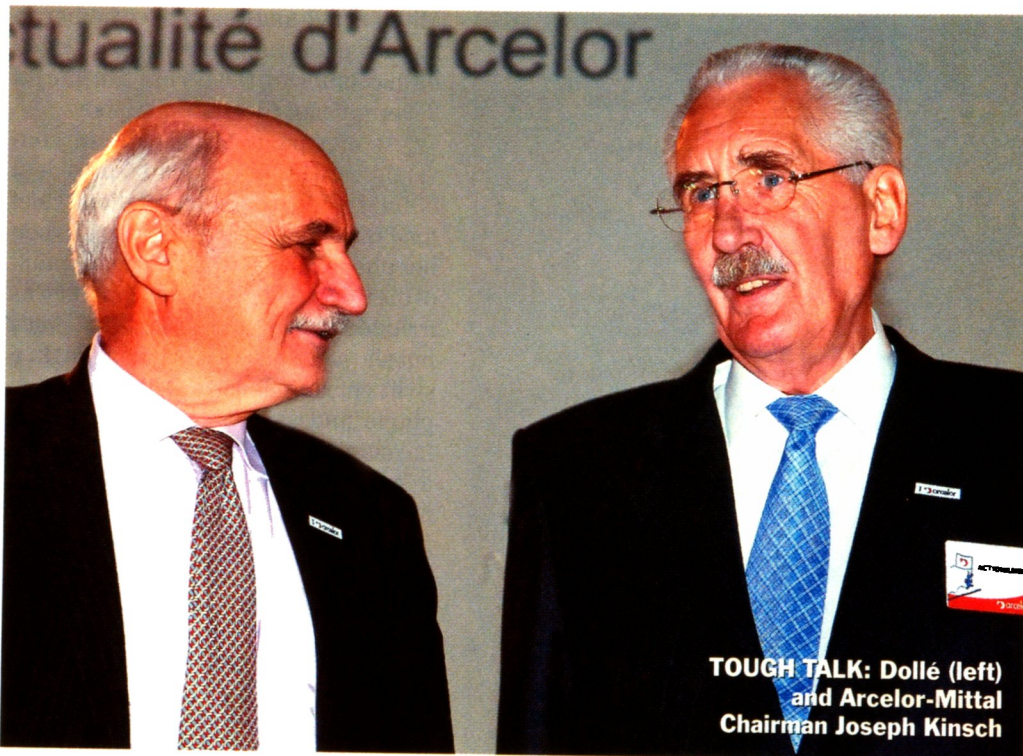




TOUGH TALK: Dollé (left) and Arcelor-Mittal Chairman Joseph Kinsch

“Guy, I am calling you as a matter of courtesy to tell you that Mittal Steel will be announcing an offer directly to Arcelor’s shareholders.”

was on the verge of a very significant success in its campaign to fend off Mittal. He did not realise, therefore, that the tiger was highly auspicious for Lakshmi Mittal. The year of his birth, 1950, was the Chinese Year of the Tiger, a beast associated with good fortune and power. It was the star of the zodiac and its element was metal.

*Friday 13 January 2006, 6 p.m.
18-19 Kensington Palace Gardens,
London*

‘His house is so big you need to catch a bus to visit the bathroom,’ Guy Dollé smirked. Alain Davezac gazed across and saw that the humour was gallows. Dollé had not wanted this meeting. Not now. His mind was miles away in Hamilton and the battle with ThyssenKrupp....

Mittal’s eyes were focusing on a much bigger agenda. ‘Guy,’ he said. Dollé stopped short.

‘I have something very important to tell you. Our two companies are both undervalued in the market. We share the same consolidation goals. We should discuss how we could work more closely together. Let’s discuss on a friendly basis.’

‘The cultures of our two companies are entirely different,’ Dollé said, barely able to hide his disdain.

Mittal shrugged and smiled patiently. ‘There is only one thing we can do for the benefit of both companies and the steel industry, and that is to merge. Where we are strong you are weak, and you have great strengths that we don’t have. If we joined forces we could be a great steel champion.’

*Thursday 26 January
9.35 p.m.
Aditya Mittal’s office*

Lakshmi Mittal sat, Aditya at his side, taking one last look at a series of

bullet points on a piece of paper. In front of him was the phone. This was to be one of the most important calls of his life. He felt calm. He was certain that what he was doing was absolutely right.

‘Good luck,’ Aditya said as his father but-toned out the number: 0033....

Five hours behind, Guy Dollé was in the Lufthansa business-class departure lounge at Terminal 1 of Toronto’s Lester B. Pearson International Airport when his mobile rang. He fished it out of his pocket and looked at it quizzically. He didn’t recognise the number.

‘Yes?’

‘Guy, this is Lakshmi Mittal. I am calling you as a matter of courtesy to tell you that tomorrow Mittal Steel will be announcing an offer directly to your shareholders for all the shares of Arcelor.’

At that very moment Patrick Seyler happened to look up at Dollé. The CEO looked like a man who was about to fall off a building.

*Thursday 7 February, 12.41 p.m.
Brussels airport*

‘Roland, are you OK for a helicopter trip to Paris?’ Mittal asked Roland Verstappen, his newly appointed director of government affairs....

An hour later it was with some relief that Verstappen spotted the Eiffel Tower to his right. It couldn’t be long before they touched down at Le Bourget. But the aircraft was now held, waiting for a landing slot. It began to circle. Suddenly to his left Lakshmi Mittal spotted another helicopter. It was circling too. Then he realised it was tailing him, and getting closer. It was close enough for him to see that somebody inside was holding up a sheet on which was printed what looked like a row of numbers. ‘Maybe it’s an offer that Arcelor will accept,’ he